centuries, both the alien invaders and the southern ethnicities helped create a more inclusive Sinic culture, with the growing Buddhist faith and a common Chinese script playing an important role in the acculturation process.

It is during these years of transition that Chinese pilgrims travelled to India and Indian monks came to China to preach the faith and, more importantly, to translate the scriptures into Chinese. Buddhist monasteries and temples began sprouting across China; the faith spread among the people and influenced art, literature, philosophical thought and, above all, the Chinese imagination.

Chinese pilgrims who travelled to India during this period and left detailed accounts include Fa Xian, Xuan Zang and Yi Xing. Fa Xian undertook his travels to India during a ten-year period (399–409 CE ), Xuan Zang from 627 CE to 645 CE , and Yi Jing from 671 CE to 695 CE . From these accounts we learn about the caravan trails through the deserts of Central Asia which linked China to India.

We also have an account of the maritime routes linking Indian ports like Tamralipti, or Tamluk, in Bengal with Chinese ports like Guangzhou, but via trading ports in South-East Asia, like Palembang in Indonesia. It is along these trade routes that Buddhism spread in Central Asia, South-East Asia, China and East Asia.

There developed a symbiotic relationship between merchants and Buddhist preachers and pilgrims. The latter often joined trading caravans or travelled in ships carrying cargoes between Indian ports and South-East Asia and China. Several monasteries were established along the caravan routes, serving not only as places of worship but also as shelters to merchant caravans. Some even served as banking and warehousing institutions, thereby promoting trade.

The spread of Buddhism also set up a demand for relics and religious materials, and spread awareness of new products too. Crystalline sugar produced in India became known in China during this period, as also precious gems, exotic spices and foods. The produce of Central Asia, such as melons and peaches, as well as the famous horses from Ferghana,